

WHY IT WORKS

Comprehension illusions are common — people nod along without forming a coherent understanding. Paraphrasing back forces active processing and catches misalignment before it becomes a costly mistake downstream.

WHAT IT IS (AND ISN'T)

- Not a stalling tactic — the check takes ten seconds and saves hours of rework.
- Not a chance to re-argue — a summary that smuggles in your preferred outcome is advocacy wearing a listening costume.
- It is a ten-second audit of alignment, run before the misunderstanding gets expensive.

THE PAYOFF

How it lands: Conversations with you end with everyone certain of the same thing.

Principle: Alignment is never automatic — the people who check it are the ones others trust with ambiguity.

What you gain

- Misunderstandings caught while they are still cheap
- Meetings that actually conclude rather than dissolve
- A reputation for precision without pedantry
- People who feel heard because their words came back accurately
- Fewer 'that is not what I meant' conversations a week later

Why most people fail at it

- They nod along, certain they understood, and discover otherwise a week later.
- Their summary quietly bends towards the outcome they wanted.
- They ask 'does that make sense?' — which invites a polite yes, not a correction.
- They summarise but do not listen to the answer, so the correction never lands.

CORE FORMULA

Pause after key exchange -> Mirror what you understood -> Check accuracy

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

After any exchange where misalignment is possible, say: 'What I understood from that is X — is that right?' Then listen.

BEST FOR

- Complex or high-stakes conversations where misunderstanding is costly
- Meetings where decisions are made verbally
- Situations where instructions or expectations are given
- Any conversation where both parties might leave with different interpretations

METHOD, STEP BY STEP

1. Pause — Pause after the key exchange

Stop at the moments where misalignment is expensive — a decision, an instruction, a commitment. The pause itself signals that what was just said mattered.

Rolling on: 'Great, sounds good, next item...'

Pausing: 'Before we move on — that felt like a decision. Let me check it.'

2. Mirror — Mirror what you understood

Say your understanding back in one or two sentences, in their language, without improving it. Neutrality is the whole discipline — a slanted mirror is worse than none.

Slanted: 'So essentially you agree the deadline was always unrealistic.'

Neutral: 'You are saying the deadline stands, but scope can flex. Right?'

3. Check — Check accuracy — and listen

Invite the correction explicitly, then treat whatever comes back as the point of the exercise. A check you do not listen to is theatre.

Rhetorical: 'Does that make sense? Great.'

Real: 'Where is that wrong or incomplete?' — then silence until they answer.

FIELD TIP

Summarise their version, not your preference.

The moment a summary drifts towards what you wish had been said, it stops being a check and becomes a negotiation. Use their words wherever you can, and make the invitation to correct you sound like you mean it.

Situation: A long discussion has just ended with a vague-sounding agreement.

Don't: 'So we all agree my plan is the way forward, yes?'

Do: 'My read is: pilot first, full rollout only if the numbers hold. Anyone hear it differently?'

PHRASE BANK

Summary Checks · Confirming understanding

- "What I am taking away from this is..."
- "Let me check I have understood: you are saying..."
- "So the upshot is X — is that right?"
- "My read of this is... does that match yours?"
- "Just to confirm: we are agreed on X?"
- "I want to make sure we are aligned — my understanding is..."
- "Before we move on — I understood that to mean..."
- "Checking: the decision we just made is..."

Check Invitations · Inviting correction

- "Tell me if I have that wrong."
- "Correct me if I have missed anything."
- "Is there something in that I have missed?"
- "Where am I off?"
- "Is my read accurate?"

Quick Checks · One-line confirmations

- "So Thursday, not Friday?"
- "Short version: you want option B?"
- "So that is a yes, with conditions?"
- "Just checking — I own this now?"
- "So we ship it as is?"
- "That is a no for this quarter, right?"

Warm Mirrors · Reflecting the personal, not just the facts

- "What I am hearing is that you are exhausted, not that you want to quit — is that closer?"
- "So the hard part is not the work, it is feeling invisible while doing it?"
- "Let me make sure I have this: it is not the decision that hurt, it is how you heard about it?"
- "It sounds like you mostly need this to be heard, not fixed — am I reading that right?"
- "So underneath it all, the worry is about your dad, not the job?"
- "I want to get this right, because it matters: you are saying the trust is what broke. Is that it?"

High-Stakes Confirmations · When getting it wrong is expensive

- "Before either of us leaves this room: my understanding is we are committing to the March date. Confirm?"
- "This is the sentence I will repeat upstairs: we ship on the ninth, at current scope. Is that sentence true?"
- "I want to read that back, because we cannot afford to be misaligned on it."
- "You are asking me to sign off by Friday — before I say yes, is that precisely the ask?"
- "Let me state my understanding for the record, and you stop me at the first error."
- "We are accepting that risk with our eyes open — is that a fair statement of what we just decided?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Walking out of a meeting without confirming what was decided

Better: Just to recap before we go...

Best: Specific summary of each decision with owner and timeline, confirmed by the group.

2. Weak: Assuming you understood without checking

Better: I think I understood — let me know if not.

Best: 'My understanding is X — is that right?' Then actually listen for the correction.

3. Weak: Summarising in a way that re-argues your point

Better: Let me recap what was said.

Best: Neutral summary that reflects what was actually said, not your preferred version.

DECISION TREE

If A decision was made verbally and you want to confirm it

Summarise the decision back in one sentence.

"So we are going with X, and the deadline is Y — is that correct?"

If You are unsure what was meant

Summarise your interpretation and ask if it is right.

"I want to check I understood — my read was X. Did I get that right?"

If Someone else is unsure what was meant

Offer to summarise for them.

"Let me say back what I understood and see if that helps."

If You are at the end of a long meeting

Summarise the key decisions and owners before ending.

"Before we close — the three things we agreed on are: ..."

SCENARIOS

End of a meeting where decisions were made

Name each decision, who owns it, and by when. — "Before we close — we decided X, Y owns it, and the deadline is Z."

After receiving complex instructions

Summarise back before starting the work. — "Let me check I have that right: you need X done by Y in Z format."

After a tense conversation where alignment is uncertain

Summarise what was agreed without editorialising. — "My understanding of where we landed is... Is that yours too?"

After a long discussion where the thread was lost

Name what you think the conclusion was. — "I want to make sure we did not lose the thread — I think the decision was X."

WORKED EXAMPLE

Without the technique

Manager: (30-minute brief) Any questions?

You: No, I think I've got it.

(You implement the wrong version of the plan.)

With the technique

You: Let me check I have this right — the priority is Q3 launch, not feature completeness, and you want a weekly Friday update. Is that the key shape?

Manager: Exactly — and the Friday update can be just three bullets.

COMMON MISTAKES

The advocacy summary

Sounds like: 'So, to summarise: I was right about most of it.'

Better: Reflect what was said, in their words — you can argue after the check, not inside it.

Asking 'does that make sense?'

Sounds like: 'Make sense? Cool.'

Better: 'What have I missed or got wrong?' — a question that makes correction easy.

Summarising everything, constantly

Sounds like: Paraphrasing every second sentence until the conversation crawls

Better: Save the check for decisions, instructions, and anything with a deadline attached.

The summary that adds new content

Sounds like: 'So we agreed X — and presumably also Y and Z...'

Better: Mirror only what was said. New items get proposed openly, not slipped into the recap.

Checking but not listening

Sounds like: 'Is that right? Great. Anyway...'

Better: Leave a genuine gap after the question. The correction is the payoff — wait for it.

READING THE ROOM

Signs it is working

- Fewer misunderstandings downstream.
- People feel heard because you reflected their words back accurately.
- Meetings end with clearer next steps.
- You catch gaps in alignment before they become problems.

Signs to adjust

- Your summary subtly restates your preferred outcome.
- You are summarising so often it slows conversations down.
- People feel you are not trusting them to be clear.
- Your summaries are too long and add new content.

WHEN NOT TO USE

- In casual conversations where paraphrasing would feel clinical or overly formal.
- When you genuinely understood and a summary check would waste the other person's time.
- In some cultures and relationships where it signals distrust or condescension.

RECOVERY LINES

Best line: 'We left that meeting with two different versions. Can we re-confirm what we actually decided?'

- "I summarised that in my favour — let me redo it neutrally."
- "I asked whether it made sense when I meant to ask what I had got wrong."
- "We left that meeting with two different versions. Can we re-confirm what we actually decided?"
- "I nodded along yesterday, and I realise now I did not fully understand. Can I check it back with you?"
- "My recap added things we never agreed. Strike those — here is what we actually said."
- "I checked, you corrected me, and I ploughed on anyway. Let me take the correction properly this time."

TECHNIQUE CHAINS

Decision-lock chain

Pause at the decision -> mirror it back -> invite correction -> confirm in writing

Before we close — I think we just made a decision. Let me check it.

We are going with the phased rollout, starting March, with Priya owning it.

Anyone hear that differently?

I will send those three lines round this afternoon so we have one version.

Instruction chain

Receive the brief -> mirror the key constraints -> check -> start work

Let me play that back before I start.

You need the summary version, two pages, by Thursday noon, for a non-technical audience.

What have I missed?

Good — I will have a draft to you Wednesday so there is room to correct course.

RELATED TECHNIQUES

TC015 — Next-Step Close

Next-Step Close is the action-flavoured twin — the summary check confirms what was meant; the close confirms who does what by when.

TC016 — Validation Without Agreement

Validation Without Agreement uses the same mirroring skill on positions and feelings — reflecting accurately without conceding anything.

TC014 — Validate the Concern

Validate the Concern starts with exactly this mirror — you cannot validate a concern you have not accurately restated.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — End-of-meeting recap

At the end of one meeting, summarise the decisions made and confirm with the room.

Day 2 — After instructions

After receiving any instructions or requests today, summarise them back before you start.

Day 3 — Check one assumption

Identify one assumption you have made in a conversation and check it explicitly.

Day 4 — Neutral summary

Practice summarising what was said without adding your interpretation or opinion.

Day 5 — The short check

Use a one-sentence summary check in three conversations today.

Day 6 — Written summary

After a key meeting, send a short email summary of what was decided.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did your checks catch any misalignments? Were any summaries corrected? Did any feel like slowing things down?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I pause at the right moment to check understanding?
- Did I summarise accurately — without adding my preferred interpretation?
- Did I explicitly invite correction?
- Did I listen to the response rather than just confirming my summary?
- Did I use this at the end of key meetings and conversations?
- Did I act on any corrections that came from the check?
- Did I avoid over-using it to the point of slowing things down?